

# TSARANG (CHARANG)

Upper Mustang, Nepal | ~3,500–3,570m

## General Overview

*Planetary Health Transect*

## Geography & Landscape

Tsarang (also written Charang) is a scenic village situated in Lo Gekar Damodar Kunda Rural Municipality in Upper Mustang, at an altitude of approximately 3,500 to 3,570 meters. It serves as the administrative center of the rural municipality and was historically the former capital of the Lo Kingdom before the seat was moved to Lo-manthang by King Ame Pal.

The landscape is classified as a trans-Himalayan cold desert — arid, mountainous, and largely barren — shielded from monsoon rainfall by the Himalayas. The soil is primarily a loose conglomerate of pebbles and sand. Despite this, Himalayan poplar trees provide pockets of greenery and shade within the settlement, and the village lies along the Kali Gandaki River bank, with settlements often clustered at corner oases along the river and its tributaries.

Key landscape features include:

- High-altitude highland (3,500–3,570m above sea level) in the trans-Himalayan region
- Cold desert classification; arid climate with very little arable land
- Extensive cave systems to the north and east of the village, including one eastern complex with 33 chambers
- Compact, dense settlement layout with flat-roofed mud-brick houses designed for harsh climatic conditions
- Narrow alleys, a ruined fortress, and traditional architectural forms defining the built environment

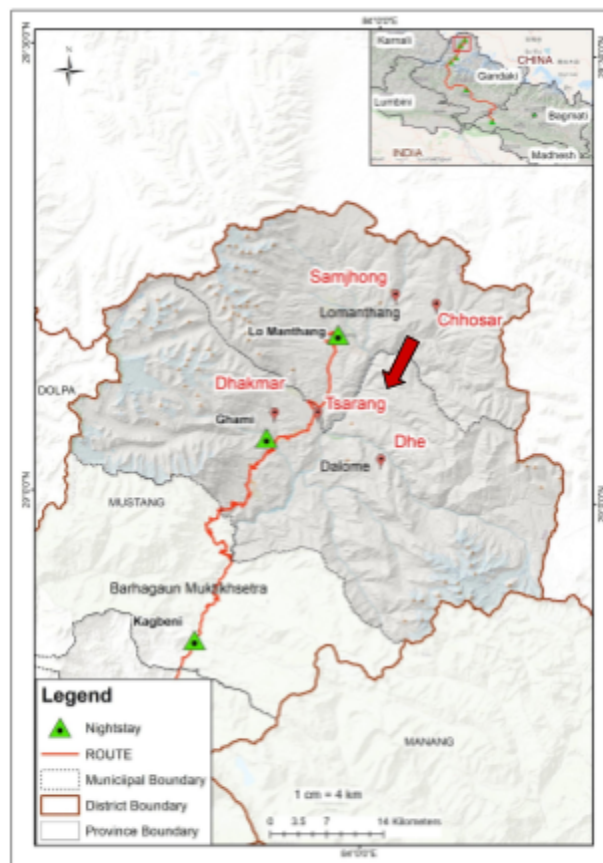


Fig. Geographical Setting of Lower Upper Mustang (Tsarang highlighted in red and pointed at)

## Climate & Environmental Conditions

Tsarang sits within the trans-Himalayan arid zone and experiences some of the most extreme environmental conditions in Nepal's mountain regions.

### Weather Extremes

The region is frequently covered by snow, and blizzard-like winds are common. The arid climate results in very low annual precipitation, with the Himalayan rain shadow blocking the monsoon entirely.

### Environmental Hypoxia

Due to its extreme elevation, all residents of Tsarang live under constant environmental hypoxia — low oxygen levels that have direct implications for health, physical capacity, and long-term disease risk.



Fig. A view of Tsarang village from afar. Credit: Anek Rajbhandari (2019)

## Historical & Religious Significance

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Tsarang has served as the cultural, religious, and administrative heart of Upper Mustang for centuries. Its historical depth makes it one of the most significant heritage sites in trans-Himalayan Nepal.

### Former Capital and Center of Learning

- Before the capital was moved to Lo-manthang, Tsarang served as the administrative center and headquarters for the region of Lo
- It has remained the region's most active religious and educational center from the time of its independence to the present day

### Charang Monastery

- The Charang Monastery (Thub-bstan-bshad-grub-dar-rgyas-gling) was sponsored by King Amadpal
- The current three-story structure dates to the 16th century and remains an active site of Buddhist practice and learning



Fig. Tsarang Monastery. Source: Regulus Nepal

## Architectural & Archaeological Heritage

### Tsarang Palace

A grand five-story structure built of mud, stone, and wood. While it remains a significant landmark, its eastern sections have fallen into ruin. The palace's second story houses a collection of ancient weapons, gold-lettered scriptures, and — notably — a severed human hand.

### Ani Gumba

An abandoned nunnery located within the village. It contains some of the oldest paintings in the area and is in urgent need of restoration.

### Cave Systems

Extensive cave complexes surround the village to the north and east, including one eastern cave with 33 chambers. These cave systems are of significant archaeological interest and are characteristic of the Upper Mustang landscape.



Fig. Ruins of Tsarang Palace.  
Source: Wikimedia Commons

## Demographics & Communities

### Key Statistics

- Population (2011 census): 452 residents (217 males and 235 females) in 132 households
- Approximately 50% of the population is considered 'income poor' by international standards
- Non-cash-dependent lifestyles sustain a standard of living roughly equivalent to the national average

### Economy

- Traditionally relied on agro-pastoralism
- Currently transitioning due to rapid globalization, road access, and trekking tourism
- Very little arable land due to arid conditions and loose sandy-pebble soil composition



Fig. A man guiding a herd of goat into Tsarang Village. Credit: Anek Rajbhandari. (2019)

## Peoples & Culture

The local people of Tsarang and Charang mainly belong to the Lo Community, who came to Lomanthang and established their separate Kingdom initially. The Lo people are primarily renowned for preserving their cultural uniqueness, vibrant festival celebrations, traditional musical forms and dances, and their nature-based lifestyles.

Since opening to tourists in 1992, the village has undergone modernization of its buildings, food, and general lifestyle — creating an ongoing tension between cultural preservation and contemporary change.

## Health Profile

Tsarang's health burden is shaped by its extreme altitude, arid environment, and the physiological stresses of high-altitude living. Environmental hypoxia is a constant background condition affecting all residents. The village is experiencing a documented shift toward chronic non-communicable diseases, particularly among older residents.

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| <b>Chronic Disease Risk</b><br>Research indicates a high prevalence of pre-diabetes and diabetes, particularly among residents over the age of 40.                                               | <b>Hypertension</b><br>High blood pressure is a confirmed public health problem, particularly among village women.                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Joint Health</b><br>A significant portion of the population reports suffering from joint pain, swelling, and osteoarthritis, likely linked to high-altitude physical labor and cold exposure. | <b>Environmental Hypoxia</b><br>All residents live under constant low-oxygen conditions due to the high altitude. This environmental hypoxia is a cross-cutting factor underlying many of the health risks observed in the community. |

## Conservation & Modernization Challenges

Tsarang faces a dual challenge: the physical deterioration of its tangible heritage due to natural exposure and the impacts of global warming, and the social transformation brought by road access and tourism since 1992.

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| <b>Infrastructure Impact</b><br>The construction of the new road has created dust and vibrations that place the Kangni Chorten and other religious monuments in a vulnerable physical condition. | <b>Cultural Preservation</b><br>Many tangible heritage sites are described as dilapidated or in a ruined state due to natural exposure and the impacts of global warming. The Ani Gumba nunnery is identified as urgently needing restoration. |
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## Planetary Health: Key Themes

### 1. Environment, Ecosystem and Biodiversity

Tsarang sits within a cold desert ecosystem where the land supports agro-pastoralism under severe arid constraints. The arable land base is extremely limited due to soil composition (loose pebbles and sand) and the absence of monsoon rainfall. Himalayan poplar trees are a defining ecological feature of the settlement oasis, providing the community's primary green cover. The cave systems in the surrounding landscape represent both an archaeological resource and a feature of the high-altitude geomorphology characteristic of the Kali Gandaki valley.

## 2. Climate Change, Hazard and Resilience

The trans-Himalayan region faces intensifying climate risks, particularly from glacial dynamics, increased snowfall variability, and the broader impacts of warming at high altitude — where temperature changes are amplified relative to the global average.

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| <b>Snow &amp; Blizzard Events</b><br>The region is frequently covered by snow, with blizzard-like big winds common. These weather extremes affect mobility, agriculture, and access to essential services. | <b>Heritage at Risk</b><br>Global warming and natural exposure have left many tangible heritage assets — including palace structures, religious monuments, and cave systems — in a dilapidated or vulnerable state. |
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## 3. Culture, Heritage and Changing Lifestyles

The Lo community's way of life has been shaped over centuries by the demands and rhythms of the trans-Himalayan environment. Their nature-based lifestyles, festival traditions, and architectural forms reflect deep adaptation to high-altitude living. Since the region opened to tourists in 1992, the village has seen accelerating modernization in buildings, food systems, and daily life, raising questions about the pace of cultural transformation and the long-term preservation of intangible heritage.

### Sources

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